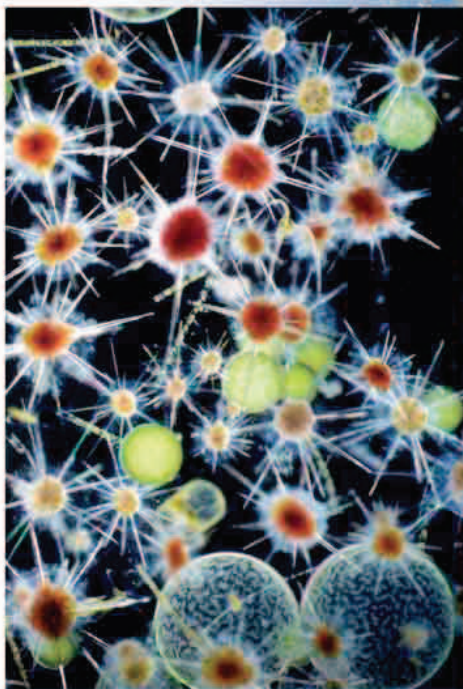


Zooplankton

The tiny drifting algae that form the phytoplankton are eaten by swarms of small animals and other organisms that cannot make their own food by photosynthesis. These organisms are known as zooplankton because they also drift with the currents, but many of them can swim. This ability enables zooplankton to hide in the dark depths by day and move up to the surface to feed at night.

PROTOZOANS

The smallest types of zooplankton have bodies made up of a single cell—unlike true animals, which have many cells. But they feed on other living things in the same way as animals, so they are sometimes called protozoans (meaning “near animals”). They include these radiolarians, which gather food using their long flexible spines.



COPEPODS

Zooplankton animals are much bigger than protozoans, but many of them are still very small. The most numerous and widespread of these animals are copepods. These tiny crustaceans—relatives of shrimp and crabs—hang in the water supported by their enormously long antennae, which act like parachutes. They eat microscopic single-celled algae and protozoans.

WOW!

So many Antarctic krill live in the Southern Ocean that their total weight is greater than that of the human population of the world.